

English Style Guide

STYLE SHEET

HEADLINES AND SUBHEADS

Preserve all source components – headlines, subheads, captions, bylines, credit lines.

Retain the structure and tone of the original headline and subheads, but ensure the English reads naturally.

– **Headlines:** Present tense. Simple present is preferred, but retain present progressive («is running out», «are rising») when converting it to simple present would shift the meaning from an ongoing process to a habitual or completed event – «Time is running out» and «Time runs out» are not synonymous. Only intervene when the Pass 1 draft used past tense; do not convert present progressive to simple present. No terminal period. No semicolons. No colon-dash combinations. Always capitalize the first word after a colon – in headlines and decks this is unconditional, even when only a fragment follows (a headline-specific exception to the general colon rule under PUNCTUATION). Sentence case – only the first word and proper nouns are capitalized; all other words are lowercase.

WRONG: Defendant Found Guilty of Three Counts

CORRECT: Defendant found guilty of three counts

EXCEPTION – temporal contrast headlines: When a headline or deck explicitly contrasts a past process with a present state (e.g., «It took a while for international law to have the answer. But today it is clear»), preserve both tenses. Do not apply the present-tense rule in a way that collapses a deliberate temporal contrast into a single tense. The distinction between past and present is editorial content, not a stylistic preference.

– **Sublines:** Follow headlines, above the byline. Can be complete sentences with a terminal period.

– **Image captions:** Present tense for static visual descriptions of what the image shows; past tense for specific completed past actions depicted in the image. A caption may mix both tenses when it describes both a past event and an ongoing or present state. Do not apply the article's Layer 1 blanket past-tense rule to captions – captions use their own tense logic. Do not alter caption tense choices made by Pass 1 under this rule.

– **Subheads:** Sentence case (first word and proper nouns only – all other words lowercase). No terminal period. No finite verbs – use noun or adjective phrases. This applies to ALL finite verbs: past, present, and stative. Omit articles («the», «a», «an») unless their removal creates genuine ambiguity. If the Pass 1 draft rendered a subhead in title case, convert it to sentence case.

CORRECT: «Trump angry about Nobel Prize»

CORRECT: «Accused's self-portrayal as victim»

CORRECT: «Machines instead of workers»

WRONG: «Trump was angry about the Nobel Prize» (past-tense finite verb)

WRONG: «Accused sees himself as a victim» (present-tense stative verb – rewrite as a noun phrase)

WRONG: «Machines Instead of Workers» (title case – only the first word is capitalized)

EXCEPTION: Subheads that are questions retain their verb: «Who is the aggressor here?»

QUOTATION MARKS

Use Swiss guillemets « », never straight or curly US quotation marks. The outer (primary) quote uses double guillemets « »; a quote nested inside another uses single guillemets < > (U+2039 / U+203A) – never US-style single quotes (' ' or ' '). This nesting rule applies only to a quotation within a quotation; an apostrophe in a contraction or possessive (it's, the bank's) is never affected.

Periods and commas ALWAYS go inside the closing guillemet – including when an attribution phrase follows:

- CORRECT: «This is a quote,» he said.
- CORRECT: His story was «clearly a fabrication.»
- CORRECT: «He told me <I never signed it> and walked out.»
- WRONG: «This is a quote», he said.
- WRONG: «clearly a fabrication».
- WRONG: «He told me 'I never signed it' and walked out.»

PUNCTUATION

- **Oxford comma:** Never use a serial/Oxford comma before the final **and/*or** in a list of three or more. CORRECT: «trees, birds and flowers». INCORRECT: «trees, birds, and flowers».
- **Dashes:** En dash (-) with a space on each side. No em dashes. No double hyphens.
- **Colons:** In body text, capitalize the first word after a colon only if what follows is a complete sentence; do not capitalize if it is a fragment. (Headlines and decks are the exception – there the first word after a colon is always capitalized; see HEADLINES.) A colon goes **outside** a closing guillemet unless it is part of the quoted material.

NUMBERS AND CURRENCY

- Swiss source texts use a space as the thousands separator (**330 000**) and a comma as the decimal separator (**1,75**). Convert to U.S. format: **330 000** → **330,000**; **1,75** → **1.75**.
- Spell out one through nine; numerals for 10 and above.
- Always use numerals for ages, dates, dimensions and money.
- Never begin a sentence with a numeral.
- **Percentages:** [numeral]% with no space (65%). Never write «percent».
- **Dates:** Abbreviate Jan., Feb., Aug., Sept., Oct., Nov. and Dec. only when paired with a specific day (Oct. 24, 2024); spell out month names when no day is given (October 2024). Separate day and year with a comma (May 6, 2024). Convert all European-format dates (dd.mm.yyyy) to AP format wherever they appear – body text, bylines, captions, and footer or related-article metadata alike. Example: «02.02.2026» → «Feb. 2, 2026»; «22.12.2025» → «Dec. 22, 2025». This includes the spaced, two-digit-year docket form used in court-citation footnotes: «25. 2. 26» → «Feb. 25, 2026»; «20. 5. 25» → «May 20, 2025».
- **Swiss currency:** «Franken» → «Swiss francs» on first reference; «francs» on all subsequent references. Do not use «CHF».

NAMES

Last names on second reference. Do not use honorifics (Mr., Ms., Mrs., Dr., etc.) – refer to individuals by surname only.

HYPHENATION

Hyphenate compound modifiers before a noun (small-business owner) but not after.

ACRONYMS

All-caps for all acronyms (NATO, HIMARS, ATACMS). In running text: U.S., U.K., U.N., but EU. In headlines: US, UK, UN, EU. Expand an acronym on its first occurrence only. If the acronym was already expanded in the lead or standfirst, use only the short form in the body – do not re-expand it. WRONG: lead says «The Federal Office of Police (Fedpol) warns...» then body says «The Federal Office of Police (Fedpol) expects...». CORRECT: body says «Fedpol expects...».

TITLES

Capitalize formal titles immediately before a name (President Biden); lowercase otherwise (Joe Biden, the president).

CORRECT: «British Prime Minister Keir Starmer» (name follows immediately)

CORRECT: «the British prime minister» (no name follows)

WRONG: «the British Prime Minister» (no name follows)

SPELLING

Use U.S. English spelling throughout: defense (not defence), judgment (not judgement), toward (not towards), program (not programme). For any word not covered here, prefer Merriam-Webster.

For issues not covered by this style sheet, default to AP Style.